The Ghost and The Misshapen Book

Aarush Das, 13 years

This story may not enthrall everyone, as its truths are often puzzling and unsettling, and so do the characters themselves. But within this story lies the gift of uncertainty and identity , privileges that you'll never take for granted again. If you are here, reading this story, just know what privileges you have, the sweet chirp of birds singing, the fresh, creamy taste of food, the magnificent sight of the trees, the floral and fresh smell of a lavender. However, most importantly, you have the pleasure of ignorance, but a clear identity, portrayed in every new moment, every experience, and every new sensation. For sometimes, knowing too much about others, and not enough about yourself can be the most horrifying experience – worse than anything you can ever imagine, something, beyond what we can conceive.

Abignale was a young teenager, just starting high school. In addition to that, he was a highly intelligent and imaginative one at that. He also was very impatient, a trait which was noticed ever since he started middle school. Thus, Abignale always wanted more of that thrill in his life, oh, but he cannot be blamed.

He had no companions, his last known genuine relationship being with his friend, Marcie. It ended abruptly, when they were in 4th grade, when Abignale rudely remarked, "You are way too mischievous, why don't you just leave me –" and soon, his last friend Marcie pulled up his fist before he could finish the sentence; he ended up breaking two things apart that day. He broke Abignale's face, it being covered in stitches after having to go to the ER considering the severity of the punch.

However, more importantly, he broke Abignale. Marcie tore him apart, stripping him of his courage, his cordial personality, and most importantly, his own identity. I remember Abignale feeling as if time was just an abstract version of a continuous loop – never exciting, never extraordinary, just not enough to please him.

And though few would remember what led to his unraveling, its weight would echo for years in silence, buried where no heart dared to look.

He was coming home from school, airpods in, listening to depressing music, not in the best of moods. When Abignale's parents find out about his detention, he knows that they are going to be extremely mad, considering that this was the third time this week. He noticed a small corridor, looking weirdly transcendental, and he stopped for a second. It would be the worst mistake of his life. Well, for as long as he lived. He just had to go through, be the bold hero, didn't he.



He went through, the paranormal views displayed making him burgeoningly more curious by the second, the darkness becoming more prominent by the moment, the air seeming thick and humid, making it feel hot across the tiny space. When he thought he could take no more, a street popped up in front of him. Nothing extraordinary, he thought at first glance, but if I could stop him to go through it, for he didn't anticipate all the possibilities of what could be just so tiny, yet so powerful of a place to be led through this misleadingly innocent pathway in the form of a road.

After his curiosity took him to the end of this wretched pathway, leading to a small library. Abignale, in excitement squealed, "What – What is this?" crazy to think that what happens after, is ... well greatly beyond just the library. Oddly, around here, the air felt immensely thinner than before, from humid to almost unbreathable. For this reason, after Abignale squealed foolishly, he had to excruciatingly gasp for air.

He slowly, however surely went up the creaking wood of the stairs. He was hesitant. "Swish!" One of the stairs behind him slid to the ground. This made him even more anxious about going up to the library. However, this was his escape. This was his way to show that he was a

brave, independent individual. Not to his friends, not to his family, however to himself. He desperately needed to restore faith in himself, his emotional situation being a roller coaster, spiraling downwards.

After what weirdly seemed like an eternity, he made it to the crooked, black door. It was white on the border, however tinted, making it seem almost fully black. The room inside looked dark, with traces of old footprints on the dusty floor. When he opened the door, he violently yanked the door back shut, as the stench was like a million fish died in there. He slowly opened the door again, trying his best to not breathe the stench and pass out. He went into the library, with a mix of disgust and curiosity.



The library looked so bijou on the outside, but Abignale wondered how it had such a deceiving nature of size. He pondered on it as on the inside, the library looked like one of the biggest buildings he ever saw. Once he went inside, the rotten stench eased out, and the Abagnale started shivering at the frigidness. It seemed like a labyrinth of rows of bookshelves. A few seconds later, he saw one oddly clear footprint. He wondered why it was so clear, and then got a bright idea. Or, at least he thought it was bright.

He would follow the footsteps, see what book it leads to, and investigate it. He was unusually excited while being scared, weirdly intertwined emotions especially pertaining to individuals who are lucky enough to get freedom like this. However, freedom always comes at a price, sometimes miniscule, sometimes too much.

However, the footsteps lead to a locked door, locked by a padlock. However, the brilliant side of Abignale knew that the padlock was really old. So, he constantly yanked at it, hoping that the rust over all those years made the padlock to be pretty tearaway. That didn't work, the padlock being newer than the library. Abignale, persistent in getting in to find the mysterious place the footprints lead to, he quickly ripped a piece of paper out to try to pick the lock.

When he tried to pick the lock, the paper worked. Thereafter, the door creakily opened, showing a clean room, besides the dusty, large footprints of the peculiar person. After he kept on following the steps, after another eternity of curiosity, leading him to the prevailing path, seeming endless, he reached. The footsteps ended there, but his curiosity didn't.

Suddenly, he heard a deepening roar, saying "Leave this bewitched place!" He jumped in fear, scared he would be known no longer for this mysterious creature may kill him. He saw the ghost, chasing after him. He spent too much time on this, however, he gave up. He has gone through too much, losing his friends, having to run away from social interactions, and in the end, having to run away from family, who used to love him so much, hoping his mother that once happily held Abignale in her arms, sweetly singly his favorite lullabies every day, didn't see a . He couldn't handle the fact that he had to hide his face from her, more than anyone. He hated him himself more than for Marcie, for his teachers, more than himself, he despised his condition, hiding from his mother. So he did the unthinkable, not out of bravery, but out of fear and a contempt for himself. He fought the ghost.

It was not easy, the ghost putting up a courageous fight. The ghost hit him with a vividly and agonizingly strong and painful uppercut to Abignale's chin. Immediately, the pain was so much it made him step back in shock, seeing stars. However, after all he went through, he was not even close to giving up. If this was how he thought of it, a form of depression, an escape to life, maybe even a less emotionally painful death, it was stupid. However, the story must continue to preserve the circle, so he must continue.

He was slashing the ghost in all corners, as it wasn't one of those untouchable ghosts, you could see and feel them like a person. A girl, to be exact, a little bit taller than Abignale, around mid-twenties. Now, the reader must be puzzled, as to how this ghost can be identified as a ghost. What if it is a normal person, also stuck, and for so long, she went mad. What if she, whoever she is, was madly crying for attention after all these years.

Well, without spoiling the whole plot and preserving the whole timeline, you're partially correct, she is crying for attention; however, without understanding the full timeline, I cannot tell you more. Hopefully, you are courageous and trust me enough to just presume that from the ethereal glow that she had while Abignale was fighting her, he could tell she was a ghost and continue reading this story.

He was breathing heavily, seeing a blurry vision of the ghost. In fact, to him, having to walk a single step felt like an extremely dreadful weight; however, his thought fighting was helping him cope. He thought the dread of his social life, the miserable and alone life he had was going away, at least temporarily. However, after a few punches, he did something he hadn't done in, well, an eternity; and I wish he did more. Maybe, he wouldn't be where he is, if he did. He vigorously laughed, having fun, through all the pain.

For the first time in an eternity, he was having fun. He finally found an escape. It may very well have been the absolute worst escape there was; but, what would you do in his shoes? How lucky are you to live peacefully, never having to go through this. Always having support, having friends, having family, but most importantly, having yourself. The themes may --
not seem so external as you thought, but they are meant to change your perception on how you see the world. What being wealthy is in reality, the fact that true wealth is not having money, not having knowledge. Real wealth is somewhere in there, deep beneath your surface. While continuing to unravel this, you must realize how wealthy you are, compared to him, before judging his actions.

While he was having the time of his life, thinking he was bold, he looked like he could defeat Mike Tyson if he really wanted to. His adrenaline surged to its highest limits, and the ghost, as anyone would have to, seeing this monster of a person, backed down. She had no more to give, as she physically couldn't give more.

What he didn't know was that she was just trying to help his poor little soul, but maybe he went too far to be saved. Well, that would be what I would say if I saw him like that, and had a second chance.

After the glorious battle ended, there was only one thing he had to do; follow the footprints. Thereafter, he ran like the wind, chasing the end to those footsteps. As I vividly remember, he was thinking of all the possibilities. What could be worth fighting so intently against Abignale.

Was it a treasure? Abignale was thinking it could be some sort of mythical gold coin, worth a lot. This assumption would seem odd, however, considering that he just fought some sort of ghost with an eerie glow, his assumption the most reasonable explanation he could think of. In contrast, what lied there, was never meant to be seen by pupils. This book intertwined the world's secrets and answered each one, but in the process was a little too accurate. After he found it, at the end of the footprints, the cover, with a greenish aura around it, said:

The Misshapen Book

When he opened the book, the pages flipped on their own. *"Yes!"* he thought, having a moment where he thought this book could take him to a reality. He didn't care if it was unicorns and rainbows or not, since, practically, he didn't care. He thought any world, filled with whatever twists and turns, would be better than this one.

However, the start of the book represented Abignale exactly. Suddenly, the lights went out, but the aura of the book made it the only highlight you could see. It seemed like he was being sucked in, but for now, he kept on reading, as his life story was being told, one word to the next.

The book went to the part where his mother held him, singing lullabies. He was a man,



known to go through stuff. He has lost friends, nice teachers, and enemies. Even though you may not like your enemies, at least you have them, always on your back. Abignale had nobody on his back, not even his own mother; and that hurt, almost somewhere deeper than the heart.

This made him cry. He wailed the most angelically-innocent, full of life tears there ever was. There weren't many tears in his eyes, but him falling to his knees, his drowsy face, and the innocence to his shaking body, made you know he was purely and intently crying. You could say he was being emotional, or even a crybaby.

When you say that though, you must remember, from what I said previously, that you could very well be the wealthiest and one of the luckiest people on Earth, being able to have a laptop to read this story online, or even being able to read it on paper. Actually, the fact that you could have someone to share this book with, the fact that you have someone to comfort you from the scary truths this book has, makes you wealthier than Abignale could ever imagine. Poor Abignale, poor Abignale.

At the end of the book, dreadful words followed. To be exact, the book said, "For his curiosity, greater than most, he will end up becoming a ghost." This genuinely scared Abignale, him going crazy. His arms were tweaking, legs shaking, he decided to do something unprecedented, just to avoid his fate. But, fate is inevitable, impossible to stop.

He decided to rip the pages of the book one by one, not knowing what would happen next. His laughing was sounding like a maniac, killing one by one, thinking he could erase his depression. However, there is never an easy cure. After he was done, he thought he got away with it. However, he was unknowingly done for, his soul being traded for his curiosity. He became a ghost.

After a few seconds, he realized that he also had the ethereal glow, like that girl. Turns out, that girl was just trying to get her voice heard, while protecting him from the dangers of The Misshapen Book. He then fell down to the ground, limp, as if trying to escape from a dream.

But it wasn't a dream. It was the worst thing that could ever happen to him. He made all the wrong decisions, not just out of curiosity though. His desperation made him think he found a final escape. In reality, he was suicidal. He wanted an end to it all. He couldn't take all of it anymore. His life was a marble, dull and lonely.

When people are suicidal like that, they try to find any escape, and they smile, not of happiness, like

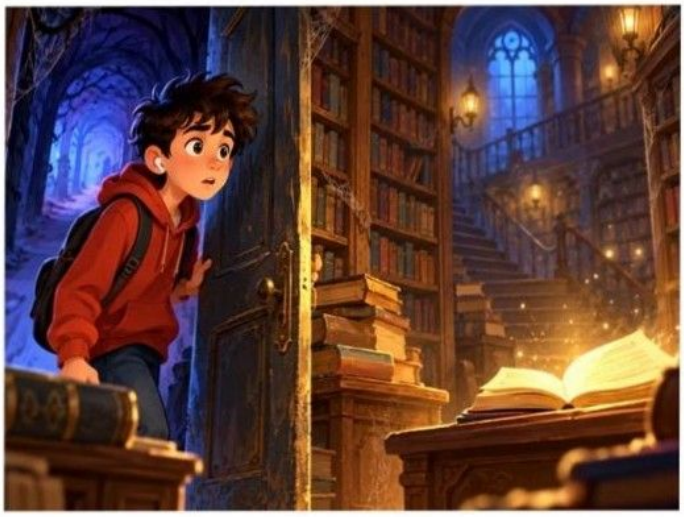
they finally beat their depression; but of the hope that they will find their final. The ending to all their problems. That is exactly what Abignale did. Or should I say I?

Perhaps, you may have noticed I know a lot, like everything about Abignale, and that is me, well, as a ghost. I know I have all the time in the world, stuck between books, and even more alone. It's painful, excruciating, almost unbearable.

Everything seems familiar and ancient, and every time I do something, it feels forceful, as if I have nothing else to do. That is because yes, I do have nothing else to do. When I thought that library was so

massive, it seemed wonderful; but now, all my eagerness, all my curiosity, is now replaced with my muttering, the scratching of books falling off, and the silence. The silence is the loudest thing you can hear, as a ghost.

What would my parents think? If anyone had a last morsel of care for me, it would be my mom. She would probably think I'm dead. And even though I'm half-alive, I was basically dead to her and me. She could stop eating, worrying about me. That is, if she thought of me as her faithful son. But honestly, I wouldn't blame her if she didn't, how bad of a son I am.



If I had to tell you something, it would be to learn from this story. Learn from my mistakes. From what this tale took you, from nothing to an understanding that boldness and foolishness are different, and it may not be so prominent in times of hardship, but is a distinct factor, one that can make you or break you. Anyways, I must put this entry in The Misshapen Book, as the cycle must continue, as life is one big circle.